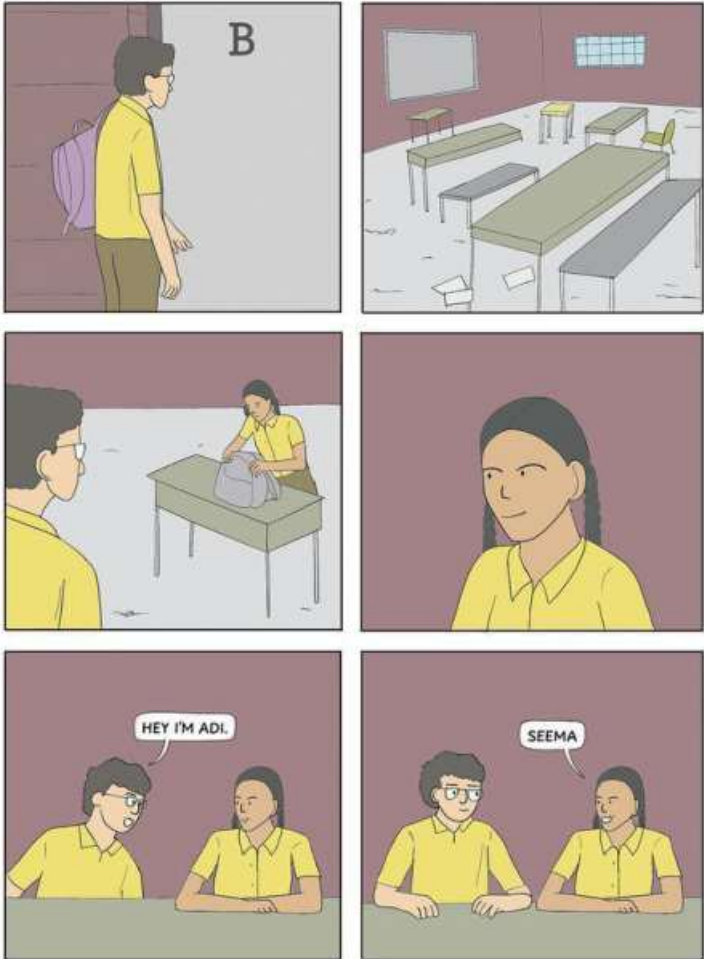




Panels from *Discovery of New* India*; and (bottom) author Aakar Patel. (COURTESY PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE, R.K. NITHIN)

Radhika Oberoi

Ink and paper are potent creators of eventful histories. When ink bends and curves in the hands of a political cartoonist, objective truths are revealed with satirical subjectivity. Tumultuous events like wars and human displacement, replicated within cartoon frames, become intimate microcosms that the reader can inhabit.

And so, with expectations heightened by my love for the graphic novel as a form of dissenting literature, I immerse myself in the *Discovery of New* India* (“Conditions Apply”), jointly created by Aakar Patel and PenPencilDraw. The title, a parody of Jawaharlal Nehru’s iconic chronicle, *The Discovery of India* (1946), offers, right at the outset, subtle insinuations that I can’t wait to unravel.

A handsome grey dog with a white beard and paws, Bagha, introduces the cast of characters: 15-year-old Adi, who has arrived in Bengaluru from the United States, young Seema, also 15, and the first in her family to attend high school, a sharp brown dog called Goopy, who has revelatory conversations with her friend, Bagha. Then there is Aakar Uncle, in whose house Adi stays. The chief protagonist, though, is the Constitution of India, which is scrutinised, its phrases magnified and discussed against the backdrop of a new India.

Earnest drawings

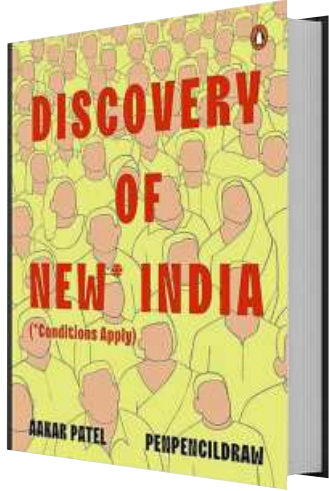
Adi, who is in India for the first time, attends school in Bengaluru, where he meets Seema, a Right to Education (RTE) student. As they walk through the school corridors and pass by the toilets, Seema asks him, “You know who works there?” Adi replies, “No, I don’t know who works there. Do you?” Seema’s

FACTS VS. ARTISTRY

Aakar Patel’s graphic novel is weighed down by excessive documentation

response is cryptic: “Yes, my people.” The narrative then offers a discursive lecture on manual scavenging, through dialogues between Bagha and Goopy, and sketches of dry latrines, railway tracks, septic tanks and gutters. The Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955, appears in the form of an outraged book. B.R. Ambedkar is resurrected to remind us how manual scavenging and the caste system are still hopelessly intertwined.

I read on, searching for clever spoofs or speech bubbles laced with wit or textures of moods and feelings that move beyond obvious indignation. In page after page, I discover ‘issues’ that flout the Preamble to the Indian Constitution, and its ideal vision of India as a sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic republic. There are explanatory depictions of the Indian Army’s Human Rights Cell, set up in 1993, and the flawed military justice system, a brief history of Preventive Detention laws, with sketches of human rights defender Arul Arumugam from Tamil Nadu, journalist Fahad Shah



Discovery of New India
Aakar Patel, PenPencilDraw
Penguin
₹799



from Jammu and Kashmir, anti-dam activist Ebo Mili from Arunachal Pradesh. Cow vigilantism and its subsequent violence against minorities (mostly Muslim wage earners) is explained by a cow, Deepjiyoti, “DJ to friends”. The 2018 Bhima-Koregaon riots are also delineated with

earnest drawings that are never fully realised.

An overstuffed treatise

This is a graphic novel whose grand premise is thwarted by its pedantic tone and style. In its sincerity lies its limitations. It unfurls with promise but flounders in over-zealousness. It is too well-researched, and too keen to impart information. There are moments, like the sketch of a jail cell with tally marks on the wall, that are suggestive of a poignant artistry that could have been. But, *Discovery of New* India*, for the most part, reads like an overstuffed treatise, trading artistry for facts.

At this point, I can’t help but mention Joe Sacco, master craftsman of comic journalism, whose reportage welded with sketches are timeless documents of historic convulsions. In his preface to *Journalism* (2012), he reflects on the tension between accuracy and imagination: “However, there are drawings – particularly in scenes that take place in the past that I did not see myself – for which I must necessarily use my imagination, or, rather, my informed imagination.” In the section titled ‘Gaza Portfolio’, Sacco depicts the Khan Younis refugee camp with a heartbreaking subjectivity that is rooted in factual veracity – rows of huts with corrugated roofs held down by bricks, tyres, and an assortment of rubble. Children crouch in narrow doorways or walk through the littered alleyways. The monochromatic sketch is steeped in a palpable despondency.

In *Discovery of New* India*, this despondency is observed and expounded, draining landscapes of imaginative freshness, reducing characters to caricatures.

The reviewer is the author of two critically-acclaimed novels.

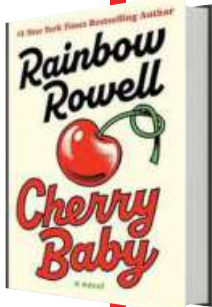
ONE FOR THE ROAD

A dash of the weird

Romance, satire and family drama, mixed in with the uncanny and unpredictable

Swati Daftuar

This month’s books circle different forms of looking back, though not always with nostalgia. In this stack, there is an estranged husband, a woman reckoning with the performance of perfect domesticity, a philosopher trying to impose order on chaos, a daughter drawn towards an inheritance she only partly understands, and a crime that unspools into something morally knottier than expected. What unites them is the pleasure of the familiar made slightly strange.



Cherry Baby by Rainbow Rowell

Rowell’s new novel is warmer, funnier and more layered than its candy-bright title suggests. Cherry, 36 and newly separated, runs into an old almost-love at a concert – sparking a sharp, generous story about timing, desire, friendship, body image and self-esteem. Rowell excels at the comedy of adult vulnerability – the awkwardness of wanting again, and the quiet thrill of being noticed.

(Penguin; ₹899)



Yesteryear by Caro Claire Burke

Its movie rights already snapped up by Anne Hathaway – the novel follows Natalie Heller Mills, a wildly successful tradwife influencer with six children, a picture-perfect ranch, and a life monetised through sourdough and domestic sanctimony. When she wakes up on the same farm in 1855, trapped in a harsher pioneer version of her own brand, the novel shifts from sharp satire to a gripping exploration of labour, religion, patriarchy and motherhood.

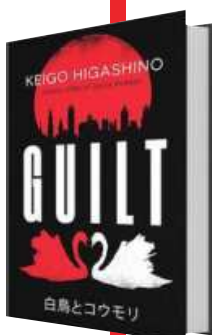
(Fourth Estate; ₹599)



Go Gentle by Maria Semple

Semple returns with her signature blend of intelligent farce and emotional depth. At the centre of this novel is Adora Hazzard, a Stoic philosopher and single mother, who is drawn into an old-money New York family and tasked with guiding their unruly children. Scandal, desire and social chaos follow. Beneath the comic momentum lies Semple’s familiar emotional core – loneliness, vanity and the struggle to stay decent in indecent circumstances.

(Weidenfeld & Nicolson; ₹661.50)



Guilt by Keigo Higashino, trs Giles Murray

It begins with a death that seems, at first, containable, but as the investigation expands, old loyalties, hidden motives and private acts of self-justification come to light. Japanese writer Higashino, best-known for his 2011 thriller *The Devotion of Suspect X*, remains one of the cleanest plotters in contemporary crime fiction. But the pleasure lies in the quiet moral pressure he builds around people making compromised choices.

(Abacus; ₹699)



The Missing Piece by Parul Sharma

Sukanya, raised in London, returns to India after growing up on stories of her father’s old *haveli*. But nostalgia quickly gives way to caste hierarchies, buried resentments and complicated histories. Sharma is less interested in tidy revelations than in the mess of inheritance – what we long for, misremember, and what is demanded from us in return for belonging. A family novel with social bite.

(Hachette India; ₹499)

(A monthly column on popular fiction.)

The writer is an independent journalist, editor, and literary curator.

Mythology in a warming world

This climate fiction novel blends ancient myth with urgent environmental and political stakes

Chintan Girish Modi

A power-hungry global elite manipulates energy prices, spreads misinformation about global warming, and profits from climate disasters, even as well-meaning activists unwittingly contribute to ecological harm.

Against this backdrop, a father-daughter duo, Rajan and Lakshmi, guards a hidden palmyra manuscript that can save the world from doom. Passed down through generations, the manuscript becomes crucial after an explosion in their village in Tamil Nadu, forcing Rajan to do anything it takes to keep

himself and his daughter safe.

With this premise, Mridula Ramesh, executive director of Sundaram Textiles and founder of the Sundaram Climate Institute, jumps onto the climate fiction bandwagon after writing non-fiction titles such as *The Climate Solution* (2018) and *Watershed* (2023).

The Pralaya Prophecy will lure fans of Hindu mythology, religious iconography and temple architecture into thinking about the impact of factories built too close to coral reefs and coal plants set up along coastlines. It will make them question hasty and inadequate environmental



clearances issued by governments. It will also alert them to the devious greenwashing that happens in the name of sustainability initiatives.

In a note that appears at the end of the book, the author writes: “The driving impulse was to reach beyond the readership of climate

non-fiction and op-eds, beyond documentaries and reels. We need greater climate action, and the more people drawn into this arena, the better.” She succeeds in keeping the reader hooked with a plot that is fleshed out like a pilgrimage trail, characters that are endearing but not impeccable and

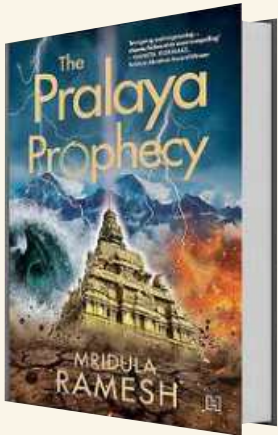
world-building that is lively and convincing.

Who gains access?

In the novel, Rajan and Lakshmi find shelter with school teacher Swati, whom Rajan does not trust at first but eventually warms up to and even falls in love with. Swati’s housekeeper Thangam

and cousin Arjun also get pulled into the mission – to unlock ancient secrets embedded not only in temples around Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh and Nepal, but within their own bodies, through yoga, *chakra* healing, *kundalini* ascension, and so on.

The novel reminds one of James Redfield’s *The Celestine Prophecy* (1993), set in the forests of Peru, and Dan Brown’s *The Da Vinci Code* (2003) that unfolds in France, England and Scotland. It



The Pralaya Prophecy
Mridula Ramesh
Hachette India
₹599

would have benefited from tighter editing as explanatory paragraphs impede the storytelling. The same information could have been conveyed through dialogue.

Unfortunately, none of the characters or the narrator reflects on why a family of priests is entrusted with the responsibility of safeguarding the manuscript. Making a girl the youngest holder of the lineage might come across as a praiseworthy feminist choice but it does not take away from the casteist angle of privileged access to scriptural knowledge and temple entry.

The book opens with a lengthy disclaimer, possibly fearing legal backlash or protests over its creative interpretation of religion and mythology.

It makes one think about the challenges to freedom of expression in contemporary India, and the paranoia that authors have to deal with when all they want to do is tell a gripping story.

The writer and literary critic’s work has appeared in the anthologies Clear Hold Build and Fearless Love.



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

Fun guide to the alphabet

Danny Bate’s book is an affectionate commentary on the eccentricities of the English language

Aditya Mani Jha

It’s always struck me as deeply silly that to describe the letter ‘h’ you have to write it down phonetically – i.e. aitch, a sound that includes the letter itself, making ‘h’ the Matryoshka doll of the alphabet. But then again, I also believe that silliness is one of the highest purposes of language, a thesis that linguist Danny Bate’s excellent new book seems to share. *Why Q Needs U* is “a history of our letters and how we use them”, as the subtitle indicates, but it is much more than that. It is an affectionate commentary on the English language’s many eccentricities, and a book-length argument that urges us to acknowledge and celebrate its ‘mongrel’ nature.

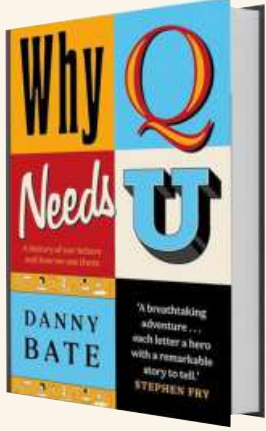
The book’s 300-odd pages are structured into 26 chapters, one for each letter of the alphabet. But what Bate is really doing here is re-packaging a (more or less) linear history of the language into bite-sized, easily digestible modules for the lay reader. How exactly was Old English informed by Latin, by the Romans, by the trajectories of conquest, consolidation, and cultural dissemination that followed every major war in the region? This is the true subject of *Why Q Needs U*, and Bate does a fantastic job of streamlining his historiographic research to meet the task at hand.

For example, the chapter about ‘N’ is really about double letters in the English language – a topic explained using double-n words like “running” or “winning” (words that have a single ‘n’ in the singular form, i.e. ‘run’ and ‘win’). Bate correctly notes that with the end of Anglo-Saxon rule in England in 1066 (the beginning of the Norman Conquest), major texts produced in this era began to diverge from then-accepted norms of Old English.

To demonstrate this idea, Bate samples verses from the *Ormulum*, a collection of nearly 20,000 verses written by a man called Orm, a name of Norse origin. Because Orm hailed from the north-east part of the country, there are Norse

influences in his spelling and usages. Notably, the first instance of the pronoun ‘they’ appears in the *Ormulum*. Bate writes: “Orm’s spelling is anything but the old West Saxon standard for writing down Old English. 1066 had severed the connection between that standard and contemporary writing. Orm seems to have been something of a visionary in the field of English spelling. For the first time, we see familiar features of the written language today being consistently used, like the digraphs WH (‘whil’) and SH (‘sholde’). In the Old English era, these had been written HW and SC, but those days were passing from memory.”

As the passage above shows,



Why Q Needs U: A History of Our Letters and How We Use Them
Danny Bate
Blink Publishing
₹499

Bate often switches from professorial to playful, and most of the chapters here wear their scholarship lightly. The chapter on the letter ‘V’ is especially entertaining and is a bit of thought experiment, almost, on all the different variants of common words that we could have had today, had one small historical development diverged ever so slightly.

Whether you are an amateur lexicographer or just somebody looking for a fun, fast-paced history book, *Why Q Needs U* has got you covered.

The writer and journalist is working on his first book of non-fiction.

Divya Gandhi
divya.gandhi@thehindu.co.in

Adrian Woolfson’s book, *On the Future of Species* (Bloomsbury), is both dystopian and full of hope. He says Artificial Intelligence (AI) could one day surpass Darwin’s evolutionary narrative on natural selection. In this new world, he predicts that AI would not just be editing, but authoring entirely new species using what he calls artificial biological intelligence. While we have managed to piece together the genomes of simple organisms like viruses, we may eventually be able to synthesise the human genome to help eradicate disease and extend lifespan. Along the way, he says, we could even resurrect the extinct woolly mammoth and the dodo. Woolfson, the co-founder of Genyry, a California-based biotechnology company specialising in synthetic genome design and construction, talks about his book on a Zoom call. Edited excerpts:

Question: You write that in the not-so-distant future, we won’t just catalogue species; we will create them. How imminent are these synthetic creatures?

Answer: We are basically shifting the paradigm of creation from a world in which life is exclusively created by evolution, by natural selection, to one in which the kind of intentionality of human design now becomes a real agency and force of creation. Now, in fact, it might surprise you to know that we have already created the world’s first computer-designed biological entity, a virus.

So, we are not talking about something in the future, we are talking about something that has actually already happened. Now, of course, to go from a virus to a zebra-like creature or an octopus or even a human is a bigger stretch. But the point is that we have already kind of taken off, if you like. It’s what I call the Wright brothers’ moment in biology.

Q: Would the newly engineered species or ‘artivolution’, as you call them, be sentient?

A: Artivolution, a phrase that I devised myself, basically captures this idea of artificial evolution. So, in other words, there is natural evolution, which is evolution by natural selection, and there is so-called unnatural evolution, which is when humans take control of designing life. There is no reason, in my view, why eventually it wouldn’t be possible to build sentient life. Whether or not we should wish to do so is another question.

We need to maximise the upside: for example, by preventing global warming by increasing the productivity of crops. Paradoxically, by creating artificial life, we can help preserve natural life and natural species, which is a key part of my aim.

Q: You have pointed to the need for the rights of machine intelligence. Could you tell us more about that?

A: Here we return to Alan Turing’s question of whether machines can

Scan the QR code to watch Adrian Woolfson in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com



IT’S THE WRIGHT BROTHERS’ MOMENT IN BIOLOGY

Adrian Woolfson talks about what he calls ‘artivolution’, and the risks and advantages of releasing engineered species into the environment



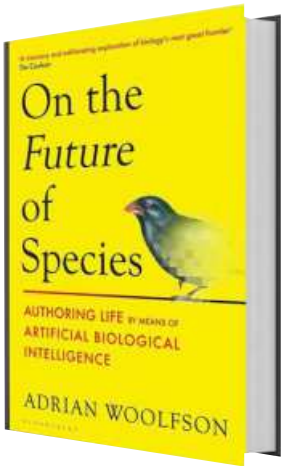
Adrian Woolfson is co-founder of Genyry, a California-based biotechnology company. (MYLA THOMAS)

ever become conscious or develop minds. And that’s a philosophical question. But it seems likely that they eventually will – not just behave as if they are conscious, but actually possess conscious awareness. If that happens, we will need to create a legal framework that protects them. The same would apply to synthetic species, if we develop forms of life that become sentient in the way you described.

Q: Artificial biological intelligence could perhaps even programme alternative versions of humankind. But this could bring about catastrophic harm, you write. Could you explain why?

A: My view is that this technology should not be used to change the nature of humans other than to get rid of diseases and to increase healthy longevity. Of course, what are the limits of healthy longevity? That’s an interesting philosophical question.

We know, for example, that among the bristlecone pine in California, there’s one called Methuselah that is about 4,700 years old. Just imagine that. We live, these days, if we are lucky, till about 90. Of course, if you lived in Victorian England, in the 19th century, you would be lucky if you lived till 30. And if you spoke to someone in the 19th century and you told them that one day in 2026, people would be living till 90 or even 120 in some



cases, they would say maybe that was unnatural, right?

Once we master the language of DNA and the grammar of DNA, it would enable us to write biology with impunity in the same way that Tolstoy was able to author *War and Peace*. Once we get to that level of sophistication, manipulating the grammar of life, we would be able to potentially entertain the possibility of totally rewriting human nature. Am I an advocate of that? No, I am not. But one needs to be aware of this possibility because it’s not difficult to imagine an authoritarian society that could decide that free will was a disease.

Q: Why are scientific attempts of de-extinction considered controversial and impractical?

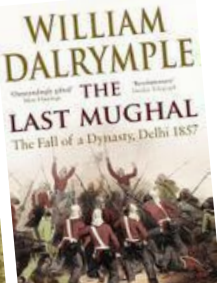
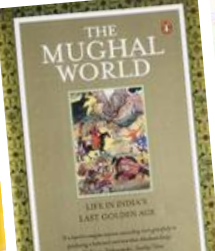
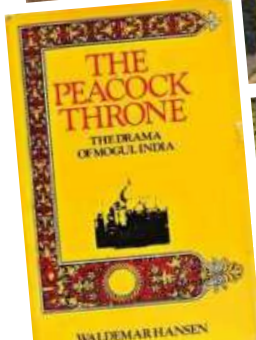
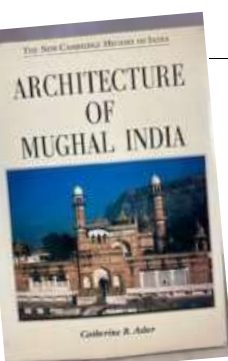
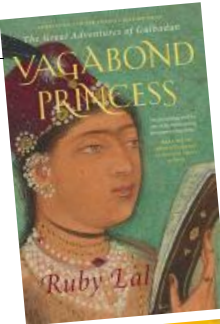
A: I have got some specific views about de-extinction, but they are unscientific in a sense. That is because they are not actually building a genome from scratch of, say, a mammoth. What they are doing is taking the genome of an elephant and engineering edits which mimic changes found in the genome of a mammoth.

So, it’s not really a mammoth genome. It’s a mimicry, if you like, of a mammoth genome.

Personally, I’m uneasy with the idea of creating these kinds of hybrid organisms and releasing them into the wild under the claim that this constitutes de-extinction for the benefit of humanity.

Peacock and power

Historian Sriram V. lists six must-read books on the history of the Mughal empire



Vagabond Princess by Ruby Lal

This is a landmark book on Gulbadan Begum, who wrote her half-brother’s biography, *Humayun-Nama*. Women are not represented in 99.99% of dynastic histories, but the Mughals were very different, because their women were also being chronicled.

Akbar: The Great Mughal by Ira Mukhoty

Here’s a brilliant modern rendition of Akbar as a person. He realised that bringing together all communities was crucial for the country’s growth. Mukhoty also writes about Akbar’s very disappointing final years, his conflicts, his failures. The last page leaves you asking about the pointlessness of being

an emperor. You feel very sorry.

The Peacock Throne: The Drama of Mogul India by Waldemar Hansen
Hansen was a pioneer. In his dramatic 1972 book, he brings in the human element. Prior to him, academics such as Sir Jadunath Sarkar and Percival Spear’s writings were very factual but dry as dust.

Abraham Eraly’s series on the Mughals

Among his brilliant set of books, *The Mughal World: Life in India’s Last Golden Age* is a fantastic look at the economy of life. It shows how the Mughal emperors as well as the commoners went through financial crisis at the same time.

The Last Mughal by William Dalrymple
Dalrymple brings to life Old Delhi and captures the empire’s decline and fall. With the East India Company coming and taking over the mutiny, you feel very sorry for the helpless and old Bahadurshah Zafar – foisted onto something he didn’t want and exiled to Burma.

Architecture of Mughal India by Catherine B. Asher
With monuments starting from Babur’s time till Aurangzeb’s, Asher gives a reign-wise, step-by-step introduction to what architectural element came with which ruler.

Read the full article on magazine.thehindu.com

GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK



UNWRAPPING THE PROBLEM

been found in the human placenta, bloodstream and brain. While their impacts on human health are still being determined, in animals they've been found to hamper essential functions, such as growth and reproduction. A November study in the peer-reviewed journal *Environment International* found that inhalable microplastics are a major urban air pollutant in several Indian cities.

No easy fix
The challenge is not simply to reduce plastic waste, but also to curb greenhouse gas emissions, microplastic pollution, and chemical exposure simultaneously. There are no easy answers. Alternatives bring their own issues. Glass is heavy, it breaks, and is carbon-intensive to produce. Paper is water-intensive, can cause deforestation, and often requires plastic coatings or chemical treatments to resist moisture or grease. Aluminium is unsuitable for food unless lined with plastic that contains BPA, a

controversial chemical linked to hormonal disruption. Bio-based compostable plastics, meanwhile, promise a fossil-free alternative but come with their own complications, from land-use impacts to a lack of composting infrastructure. Compostable plastics that end up in landfills can slowly break down to release methane, a potent greenhouse gas. Recycling, the industry's foremost solution, has long been economically unviable for a majority of plastics. Reuse, meanwhile, is hindered by major logistical and economic challenges. One way forward is to drastically simplify the range of plastics – and chemicals – we rely on. Policymakers could greenlight a narrow, carefully vetted set of materials, designs and additives. This would reduce costs and complexity, immediately improving the prospects for both recycling and reuse, while limiting health harms. This more limited array of packaging could be carefully designed to shed fewer microplastics. On top of this, policies to ensure the price of materials reflects their full environmental and social cost could reinforce simplification by driving a shift towards packaging that's easier to reuse or recycle. Beyond specific policy fixes,

however, a broader reckoning is overdue. Plastic, while a key determinant in creating the convenience culture we're so deeply wedded to, has also been a powerful engine of ever-expanding consumption. As Bhide alluded to nearly 70 years ago, plastic packaging was often deployed less to meet human needs than to stimulate demand. In their rush to harness plastic's many advantages, companies built entire business models around disposability, without pausing to ask what the long-term costs might be. Those costs are now starkly apparent – in polluted landscapes, rising emissions, and growing evidence about plastic's impacts on human health. Plastic has immense benefits, and I don't believe it will, or should, disappear, but the world could use far less of it, far more carefully. We should preserve the benefits that genuinely matter while unwinding our dependence on the vast quantities of throwaway packaging that have become normalised. Much of it we could live without. Increasingly, we cannot afford to live with it.

The writer is a journalist and the author of Consumed: How Big Brands Got Us Hooked on Plastic (2025).

Even committed efforts to go plastic-free can collide with the scale of global plastic production. (GETTY IMAGES)

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Changes, big and small
"Plastic in itself is not a bad invention. [The problem] is how mindlessly we are consuming it," says Krishnapriya A., co-founder of Sprecco Recycling, a Chennai-based plastic waste recycling company. "All medical applications of plastic have been useful in bringing down cost and increasing affordability. The problem began when we started using it for packaging convenience and made it single-use. Single-use disposables, be they plastic or paper, are a menace," she adds.

While systemic concerns dominate the discourse, consumers attempting to reduce plastic use often encounter a very different set of everyday realities. Chennai-based pilot Nikitha Gupta has been "plastic-free" for a few years now. She saves paper, cloth and plastic bags for reuse and makes it a point to return polythene bags to vendors. Gupta and her husband have also managed to convince their local tender-coconut seller to ditch plastic straws. Despite these attempts, "going 100% plastic free is nearly impossible", she says, especially when bananas purchased online come wrapped in cling film, and apples and pears in foam packaging.

Gupta adds that she faces "a lot of judgement" for her choices. "People can't fathom why I refuse a plastic bag while shopping, or why I carry my own box when dining out, to take home leftovers." When she asked her laundry detergent supplier to take back empty containers, they



THE PLASTIC BLAME GAME

under my kitchen sink. I regularly give away paper waste – such as newspapers and cardboard – to the neighbourhood waste picker, but for plastic items such as food packets and oil bottles, a reliable recycling solution remains elusive.

No doubt, sustaining a plastic-free lifestyle can prove challenging in the long term. "It was easy during the lockdown, but tough to cope once the world opened up. Life changes aside, I did not want to spend more than 10% on a plastic-free product unless the quality was top-notch," says Malhotra. For example, the approximate cost of getting a 5-kg pack of whole wheat ground at the local mill is around ₹500, including cost of transport to and from the mill. In contrast, a 5-kg pack of *atta* at the supermarket will cost you less than ₹300.

The waste conundrum
In India, about 9.3 million tonnes of plastic waste is generated annually. Sprecco Recycling handles 45-55 tonnes of plastic waste every month. It is sourced from urban and rural local bodies, waste aggregators, industries,



People can't fathom why I refuse a plastic bag while shopping, or why I carry my own box when dining out, to take home leftovers

NIKITHA GUPTA
Chennai-based pilot



Single-use plastic has become ubiquitous since it has replaced a wide variety of materials. For sustainable alternatives to have the same level of usage, bans have to be accompanied by economic measures, the promotion of alternatives, and changes in consumer habits

RAVI AGARWAL
Founder, Toxics Link, Delhi



It is always better to reach out to local NGOs or civil action groups and resident welfare associations that are working with environment-related issues in their locality, to mobilise action

ANN ANRA
Founder trustee, Wasted 360 Solutions, Chennai

What can be recycled?

● **Polyethylene terephthalate (PET):** Commonly used in food packaging and bottles. It is the most widely recycled plastic in the world with a majority of it being turned into clothing. It is an ideal material that can be used in construction too, and also turned back into PET bottles.

● **High-density polyethylene (HDPE):** Used to make bottles, pipes, toys, etc. It is one of the easiest plastic polymers to recycle.

● **Polyvinyl chloride (PVC):** Used in construction and flooring, and is not recyclable under normal conditions.

● **Low-density polyethylene (LDPE):** Cheap and low-quality plastic that goes into grocery bags, bubble wrap, etc. It is not a financially viable plastic to recycle.

corporates, tech parks, residential communities and institutions. "We are working to build relationships with corporates to receive their post-consumer and industrial plastic waste," says founder Krishnapriya.

A large portion of plastic waste in the country is handled by the informal sector, especially waste pickers. "60% of the plastic is recovered in India, of which 90% is collected from the informal plastic supply chain that includes waste pickers, waste buyers, scrap dealers, and aggregators," says Nalini Shekar, co-founder of Bengaluru non-profit Hasiru Dala Innovations, which integrates waste pickers into the evolving circular economy value chain.

As Gardiner says, the industry talks a lot about consumer demand for plastic, essentially blaming people for its own ever-increasing production. "We normally think about goods being produced because people want to buy them. But a lot of plastic comes from oil and gas by-products that would otherwise go to waste. The industry is pushing plastic into markets because it's a way for them to make money from substances that would otherwise be worthless. That's why plastic is so cheap. And plastic's low price is the reason it's everywhere. As consumers, we're not demanding plastic – we just can't avoid it," she says.

The truth about recycling
According to Shekar, saying no to non-recyclable plastics and reducing use of single-use plastics is key to solving the problem of excess waste generation. "Consumer forums should be actively leveraged to build awareness and drive collective action. At the same time, the government must strengthen its campaigns under Mission LIFE

What's in your ice cream cup?

There are seven main types of plastic resin – some with potential to recycle, while others are hard to recycle, says Krishnapriya A. of Sprecco Recycling. "The seventh category titled 'others' encompasses a variety of waste that people cannot classify. All small-scale manufacturers use these plastics," she says, adding that there is no uniformity among plastic products based on what they are made from. "For example, every brand of ice cream uses a different resin in their cups, so sorting them according to commodity type is extremely difficult. Also, some products carry the recycle logo, but don't mention the resin type. We recommend that materials are designed keeping in mind their end of life use."

(Lifestyle for Environment), which promotes behaviour change at the individual and community level," says Shekar.

If we are to look at the recycling value of plastic, Shekar says the lightweight and durable PET is the "most recyclable and has the strongest market value", followed by HDPE (used for shampoo or oil bottles) and PPE (industrial use). "Multilayer plastic packaging [sachets, chips packets, candy wrappers] is the most problematic. It has little to no recycling value, does not fetch money for waste pickers, and even paid scrap dealers are reluctant to handle it because it is bulky and expensive to store relative to its value."

Ravi Agarwal, founder of New Delhi non-profit Toxics Link, says that the solution lies in ensuring products are designed for recyclability and reuse. "Once plastic becomes waste, one can only compress it into boards or something similar. At some point in their life cycle, these will also become waste. We have to tackle packaging. We have not done that in India so far."

Packaging is increasingly a

design problem, not just a waste problem, adds Agarwal. "Different countries have varying approaches. For example, Europe's 2025 PPWR regulation reflects this shift, setting rules for how all packaging is designed, made, used and recycled. India's system still leans on post-use cleanup, though new requirements are beginning, slowly in the case of plastics, to reshape material choices and design."

As for a ban on plastic, Agarwal believes they are successful only to an extent. "Single-use plastic has become ubiquitous since they have replaced a wide variety of materials. For sustainable alternatives to have the same level of usage, bans have to be accompanied by economic measures, the promotion of alternatives, and changes in consumer habits."

Currently, countries such as Rwanda, Kenya, Germany, South Korea, and Chile take the lead in policies that have been implemented via strict bans on single-use plastics, high recycling rates, and functional Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) schemes. In Germany, a Packaging Act holds producers responsible for waste generated, and in Australia, supermarket majors such as Coles and Woolworths have phased out single-use plastic bags, which has resulted in over 80% reduced usage.

That is something I can get on board with. Rather than fret over the possibility of microplastics from my blender getting into my son's smoothie or toxins leaching into *dosas* from the nonstick pan, I choose the smaller wins: carrying the cloth bag to shop, shopping at the plastic-free neighbourhood farmer's market every month, and more importantly, teaching my son the importance of such practices. Now, he nudges me to hand him his own cotton tote before we head out to the mall.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Papiba Bhattacharya

Shashwat Ghosh, 25, wakes up at 6 a.m. and takes a shower. A routine is important to him. He runs marathons to keep fit. Having worked in a hotel, he runs a small baking business within his Bengaluru apartment complex, with orders coming in on a WhatsApp group called Baker on the Block, created by his mother. Now on a break, he is learning about managing money, digitally.

When neurotypical people meet Shashwat, his speech might sound garbled; his insistence to be physically close while interacting can annoy some, especially women. His parents Malvika and Swapan hold awareness drives in their apartment complex to acquaint others with his condition. Shashwat is autistic, his mind processes things differently. One day, a neighbour found him spinning around on a bicycle in his apartment's walking track, mumbling rapidly, with his hand bleeding. She rushed to alert his grandmother. Shashwat lives with his parents and grandmother, and finds it difficult to communicate to others about bodily injury. "My husband and I are always worried about what will happen to him after us," says Malvika. That persistent worry led them



AUTISM AWARENESS MONTH

AUTISTIC AND LIVING SOLO

Affluent parents concerned about their autistic children's future and independence are building or booking flats at assisted-living facilities

to opt for a new facility at Akshadhaa Assisted Living's upcoming campus near Bengaluru, where special-needs individuals will live independently from their parents but remain in regular contact.

Living alone together

The Ghosh family was on the lookout for a genuine and transparent arrangement, and their needs aligned with the facility, which promises a nurturing, restriction-free environment. They purchased an apartment for themselves at around ₹1 crore and a smaller one for their son Shashwat, at around ₹60 lakh.

The "what after us" anxiety faced by parents or their fear of outliving their caregiving role are what propelled the rise of

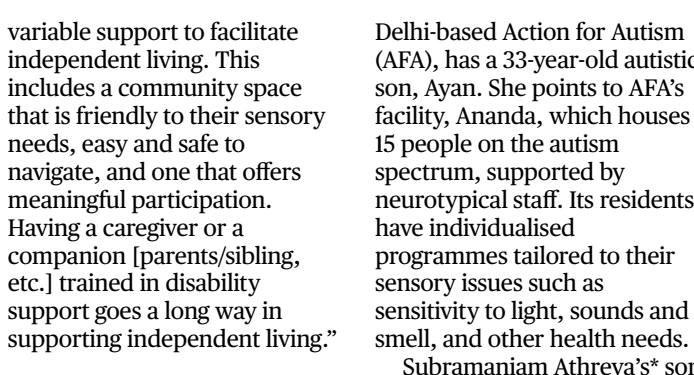


such private facilities globally. In many cases, parents and NGOs drive these institutional-care models. While there is institutional care in India from charitable

organisations or the government (group homes under The National Trust's Gharaudana scheme) for those without financial resources, living conditions vary.



A home of their own (Clockwise from left) Shashwat with parents Malvika and Swapan Ghosh; Akshadhaa Assisted Living coming up near Bengaluru; Shashwat Mittal; Ananda facility in Delhi NCR; Divya Chandana with daughter Radhika; a model living facility for representation; Shashwat baking; and Indrani Basu with son Aayan. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, GETTY IMAGES)



"We plan to keep money in a trust and appoint relatives/ friends as trustees," explains Malvika. One such friend is Anirban Dutta, a trustee at the NGO, Akshadhaa Foundation. Under its aegis, he started Akshadhaa Assisted Living, along with a group of families with special needs children, driven by the concern for his autistic daughter's future and society's insensitivity towards neurodiverse people. "We do help the children pursue their own special interests or vocations so that they are independent," says Dutta.

Such living spaces are only coming up now across India. Dr. Harshini Manohar, assistant professor of child and adolescent psychiatry, NIMHANS, Bengaluru, says, "Autistic young adults require

variable support to facilitate independent living. This includes a community space that is friendly to their sensory needs, easy and safe to navigate, and one that offers meaningful participation. Having a caregiver or a companion [parents/sibling, etc.] trained in disability support goes a long way in supporting independent living."

Parents as torchbearers

Malvika says her son was sensitive to sound as a child and would cover his ears when a train passed by. Today, Shashwat can take such sounds in his stride. To help residents navigate assisted-living facilities sensorially, architects suggest using simple colours, plain text, consistent writing, adjustable lighting, soundproof walls, and so on.

Indrani Basu, an autism advocate and therapist, as well as the head of a parent-child training programme at

Delhi-based Action for Autism (AFA), has a 33-year-old autistic son, Ayan. She points to AFA's facility, Ananda, which houses 15 people on the autism spectrum, supported by neurotypical staff. Its residents have individualised programmes tailored to their sensory issues such as sensitivity to light, sounds and smell, and other health needs. Subramaniam Athreya's son, Manish, 30, walks only under the supervision of his father or caretaker. Manish is non-verbal and subject to epileptic seizures. Keeping his son's independent future in mind, Athreya is readying a facility on Bengaluru's Doddaballapur Road, along with other families of autistic young adults. He says, "Each autistic individual is different. Though bracketed together, they do have different health needs, among other things, and they come from different backgrounds."

At a recent panel discussion by Advocacy, some autistic individuals said they would prefer staying in their own homes. AFA's Basu feels that the next best approach for families like hers would be for the autistic individual to continue to live in their own home with tailor-made outside support. "My urban son would like that, with access to a mall and other facilities he's used to," she says.

Dr. Sanjeev Jain, Professor Emeritus in the department of psychiatry at NIMHANS, who has met several parents with these concerns, says, "Autism is a very broad category, so this issue is quite complex. Most treatments and interventions are tailored for the individual after assessing the nature of the illness."

Home and the world

Healthcare industry professional Diwakar Mittal's 14-year-old non-verbal autistic son Shashant stays at Radhika Foundation's assisted-living facility in Hassanpur Tauru village, Gurugram. Mittal says his son "has adjusted well to this facility" and the environment.

"I visit him regularly. A set of teachers and a caretaker take good care of him. I do notice some improvement in him since the time he started. They have a facility for parents to stay close by if they want," he adds. The Foundation's owner Divya Chandana has an autistic teenage daughter, Radhika, who lives in the facility along with 99 others.

There are no one-size narratives for spectrum reality. The question also arises if these solutions are inclusive, as private, often expensive, residential ecosystems are accessible only to the affluent. The "independent autistic adult" narrative can marginalise those with severe disabilities, and their caregivers. Also, independence is not synonymous with "moving out". It can mean decision-making and supported autonomy within family settings.

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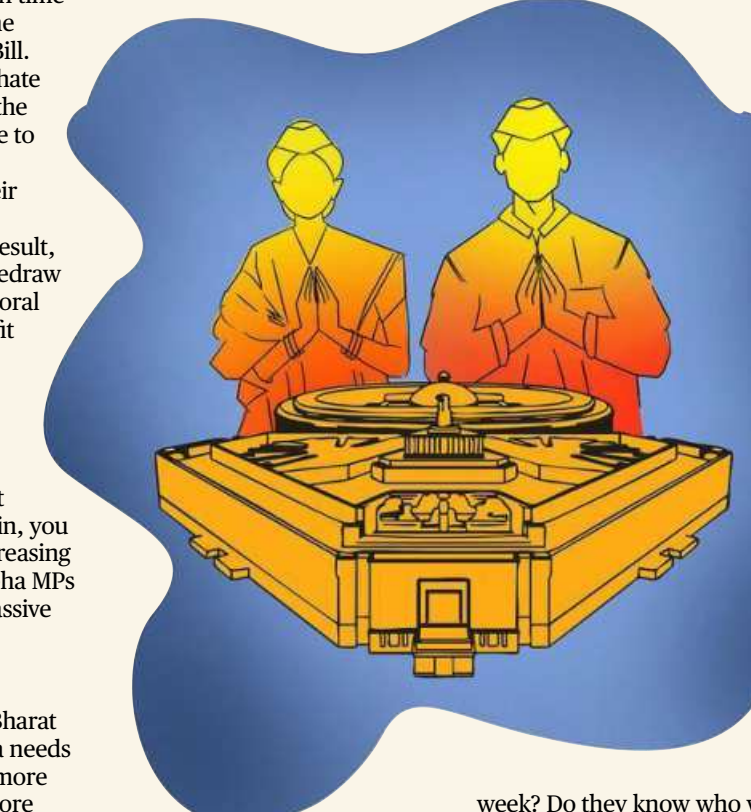
(Names changed on request.)

The writer is based in Bengaluru and writes on health, science and society and other matters.

ALLEGEDLY

India needs more MPs

Why only 850 when 147 crore legislators can be supported by the prosperous Indian tax payer?



I can't tell you how angry I am with India's Opposition parties. India's mothers, sisters and daughters (excluding those of wrestlers, Unnao, Kathua, Hathras, Manipur) will give a befitting reply to the INDIA bloc for their monumental betrayal.

Such shameless hypocrites! They themselves voted in favour of the *Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam* when it was passed in Parliament in September 2023. But in April 2026, India's Opposition leaders travelled back in time – to 2023 – to defeat the Women's Reservation Bill. That's how much they hate women! But that's not the only harm they've done to India's women.

A bigger crime is their wilful sabotage of the Delimitation Bill. As a result, we can't immediately redraw the boundaries of electoral constituencies to benefit the only deserving political party in India. Who does it hurt? Women. The logic may not be obvious at first, but if you think about it without using your brain, you will realise that not increasing the strength of Lok Sabha MPs from 543 to 850 is a massive setback for women's empowerment.

Also, the biggest beneficiaries of Viksit Bharat are women. What India needs the most – to become more Viksit, and therefore more women-empowered – is more MPs. As we rightly fling brickbats at the Opposition, let's not forget to give kudos to the Modi government for its courage to tie the Women's Reservation Bill with the idea of increasing our MP population.

The employment problem

Please understand. When we got independence, we were a poor country. We could afford to provide MP salaries, MP bungalows, and MP privileges like cars with revolving blue light and VIP number plates to only 489 Lok Sabha MPs. As the years went by, India prospered. By 1977, Indian tax payers could support the

lifestyles of 543 MPs. Post-1977, our economy has expanded enormously. We are now the fourth largest – sorry, fifth largest, sorry, sixth largest – economy in the world. Clearly, we can afford to support way more than 543 MPs. In my opinion, even 850 is too modest.

Some Opposition leaders keep parroting the 'urban naxal' line that what India needs is more schools, more hospitals, more investment in public infrastructure like roads and drainage systems, and God forbid – more jobs. Do these people ever read the newspapers? Do they know what happened in Noida last

week? Do they know who was behind the extraordinary violence? Let me spell it out: people with jobs. They were the ones who allegedly burnt cars and blocked traffic and got me stuck in a jam for five hours. It was the full-time employed, not the innocent unemployed that did it. Why did they do it? They wanted higher wages.

The whole episode, which has shaken the ancient, peaceful civilisation of Noida, would've never happened if these unruly individuals didn't already have jobs and wages. Had they been unemployed, they wouldn't have hit the streets accusing employers of exploiting them. Given

that the problem was employment, the solution is clear: more unemployment. Here's where having more MPs would help.

Mother democracy

By the way, I made a few calls to find out what these striking workers were producing. Turns out they were making nuts – yes, nuts. Hex nuts, lock nuts, flange nuts, wing nuts. The enlightened people of New India know nothing about these nuts. They don't care if there are 543 less wing nuts tomorrow than there were yesterday. But psychotic nuts, sociopathic nuts, narcissistic nuts – we love those. We obsess over them, break friendships and dissolve marriages over them, and if we want more of those nuts shaping our lives – and who doesn't – delimitation is a must.

The existing 543 MPs could only partially decimate manufacturing. Sure, demonetisation killed millions of jobs. But as the Noida incident showed, it failed to kill all jobs. If we seriously wish to increase joblessness, we need to up our game on economic misgovernance. What better way to do it than to have unlimited MPs? The easiest way to ensure no money is available for expanding social infrastructure or boosting demand (dangerous moves known to create jobs) is to spend all tax revenue on public servant upkeep. Instead of ₹850, increase the MP count to 8,860,850.

Or even better: make every one of the 147 crore Indians an MP. We'll achieve not only 'one person, one vote' and 'one vote, one value' but also 'one person, one MP'. It will turn India into the Modi of Democracy Pro Max Ultra X10. It will also instantly resolve the Women's Reservation issue, as every woman will be an MP. I hope the Opposition is listening.

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.



On a crisp April day, having finished lunch and afternoon prayers, I joined Phuphee outside on the verandah. The sun shone blindingly bright, but a gentle nip could be felt in the breeze. The tug between spring and summer had officially begun.

Phuphee was smoking her cigarettes when she saw me walk in. She smiled and asked if I had done my prayers. I nodded, and she asked, ‘Paanas kheatre kyah monguth [what did you ask for yourself?].’

‘Goanhaen maefyi [forgiveness for my sins],’ I replied, a little amused by her question.

‘Well, that is a start. But that isn’t praying for yourself, is it?’ she asked.

I looked at her, trying to work out if she was having a little laugh at my expense, but she continued, ‘You should pray for yourself as you pray for other people.’

‘Is that what you do?’ I asked her.

‘But, of course,’ she replied. ‘You don’t?’

‘Well, when I pray, I start by asking for forgiveness for my sins. And then, in order of importance, I ask God for things for other people, like my mother and father first, then my siblings and so on. I do ask for other things for myself. I pray for help or courage,’ I explained

‘That sounds like a very efficient way of praying for other people. But asking for help and courage sounds vague, if you ask me,’ she said, a little smile playing on her lips.

I sat there thinking, and watching her smoke her cigarettes.

‘Is there a better way of praying for myself?’ I asked.

She was silent. She finished her two cigarettes and stubbed them



ILLUSTRATION: ZAINAB TAMBAWALLA

A LITTLE LIFE SHE SHOWS UP FOR HERSELF

When Phuphee served sooj halwe and a little self-respect

out in an ashtray.

‘Myoan shoosh [my lungs – a term of endearment],’ she replied, ‘I am not thinking about a better way of praying. I am more concerned that you do not feel that you should be using this moment, this opportunity, for yourself, as you do for others. That worries me.’

I didn’t have an answer, not a clear or an explicit explanation anyway. In my head lay a vague understanding of why I never prayed for myself with the same fervour as I did for others. Phuphee kept watching me with a searching look in her eyes. She called for Aisha, the household help, and asked her to bring us bowls of sooj

halwe (semolina halwa) and hot kehwa (a hot drink made with cardamom, cinnamon, saffron and slivers of almonds).

‘Khaende syith yee asye kaadyen

hyekath [our brain will gain some strength with a dose of sugar],’ she said with a little wink.

Aisha brought in bowls of steaming halwe, which we

gobbled, and washed it down with a hot cup of kehwa.

‘Look around you, myoan toath [my loved one],’ she said, pointing in the direction of her garden, which had started to bloom into a million different colours.

‘Everything in nature nourishes itself first and then shares itself with the world. Look at those mighty chinar trees. They draw up water from the ground and turn towards the light, because that is what is needed for them to be alive. When they are big and strong, only then are they able to let others sit in their shade. It is noble to give and share, but to constantly deny yourself that which you give so freely to others is a sin, a very grave sin indeed.

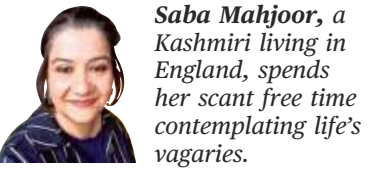
Self-love is worship, don’t let anyone tell you otherwise.’

I sat there trying to work out how this thought had never occurred to me before. Why had I never thought to pray for myself? The ideas that I had trouble verbalising clearly earlier, now made themselves known.

I had never prayed for myself properly before because as a child I had been taught that my worth primarily lay in what I could do for others. All the elders around me would talk about being a dutiful daughter, a caring sister. And though it was never explicitly stated, it was always implied that a woman’s worth lay in what she could provide for those around her. This ideology had slowly permeated into every aspect of my life, in how I conducted myself with others and how I treated myself, including how little I thought of myself in my conversations with my creator.

It didn’t seem like a life changing lesson at the time, but this little practice of showing up for myself in my own prayers altered my brain in ways I could never have imagined. Over the years, when life threw punches and I fell flat on my face, I always knew that though people who ought to show up didn’t, I always would.

I showed up for myself every single time, without fail. And if that wasn’t worship, I don’t know what was.



Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life’s vagaries.

Bob Jones

GOREN BRIDGE

The mighty five

Neither vulnerable, North deals

North opened an off-shape one no trump, which did not have much effect on the auction. North-South reached the best game contract available to them. West in today’s deal was Gunnar Hallberg. Hallberg is a native of Sweden, but he has lived in London for many years, playing rubber bridge for

the highest stakes he can find. He has made occasional forays into the tournament world with notable success. All the world’s best players know exactly who he is.

Hallberg started by

cashing his two top hearts. Not seeing anything better to do, he continued with a third round of the suit. Declarer ruffed with dummy’s jack and discarded a low club from his hand. He led a

spade to his queen, losing to Hallberg’s king. Hallberg led a fourth round of hearts. East ruffed this with the five of spades, promoting Hallberg’s trump holding into another trick. Down one after a lovely defense. It would not have helped declarer to ruff the third heart with dummy’s six of spades. If he then overtook the jack of spades with the queen, Hallberg would

win and a fourth round of hearts would achieve the same promotion. Should declarer run the jack, Hallberg would duck and South would not be able to get off the table effectively. There is a winning play. South has to win the first round of spades with his ace and continue with the queen. That would prevent the uppercut and bring home the contract.

NORTH			
♠	J 6		
♥	8 6		
♦	A K 8 6 4 2		
♣	A K 7		
WEST		EAST	
♠	K 8 7 4	♠	5 3
♥	A K 10 9 7 3	♥	Q 5 4
♦	Q 3	♦	J 10 9 5
♣	6	♣	10 5 3 2
SOUTH			
♠	A Q 10 9 2		
♥	J 2		
♦	7		
♣	Q J 9 8 4		

The bidding:			
NORTH	EAST	SOUTH	WEST
1NT	Pass	2♥*	Dbl
Pass**	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♦	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠	All pass		
*Transfer to spades			
**Denies 3 or more spades			

Opening lead: Ace of ♥

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

In the month of the Bard



Fate of Ophelia A painting of Ophelia from Hamlet by 19th century British artist John Everett Millais. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

On April 26, 1564, William Shakespeare was baptised in Stratford-upon-Avon, England. More than 400 years later, his influence endures. Currently, 22 celestial bodies orbiting a planet are named after characters from his plays. What are they collectively known as?

This idiom appears in *The Taming of the Shrew* (Act I, Scene 2). Tranio advises Petruchio to begin wooing Katherine by softening her cold and aloof demeanour. What common phrase originates here?

The Fault in Our Stars (2012) is a bestselling novel by John

Green, which was eventually made into the Hindi film *Dil Bechara* (2020). The title comes from a play where Cassius says, “Men at some time were masters of their fates,/ The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars,/ But in ourselves, that we are underlings.” Which titular character is being referred to here?

This phrase comes from *Julius Caesar* (Act I, Scene 2), where Casca describes Cicero’s speech as something he couldn’t understand: “It was ____ to me.” What common phrase completes this quote?

In *Romeo and Juliet* (Act II, Scene 4), Mercutio says, “Nay, if thy wits run the ____, I have done,” referring to a futile pursuit. The reference is to a horse event where the animals follow an

unpredictable leader. What common phrase completes this line?

Although derived from an older Dutch expression, this phrase was popularised by *The Tempest* (Act V, Scene I). Trinculo uses it to describe his disoriented, drunken state and asks: “How camest thou in this ____?” Referring to his state rather than a condiment, what is the phrase?

The first recorded use of this term appears in *King John* (1590s). It describes someone unemotional or cruel, based on the old belief that colder blood indicated lack of feeling. What is this term, now common in crime fiction?

In a Metallica song, the chorus says “Where’s your crown, King Nothing?” This is a reference to which titular Shakespearean character, who gives away his kingdom foolishly and subsequently becomes a king of nothing, losing his power, authority, and sanity?

“*The Fate of Ophelia*” is the lead single from a pop singer’s recent album. The song addresses a soulmate who saves her from a destiny of death, like that of Ophelia in *Hamlet*, where she drowns owing to the madness that came from grief and rejection. Which pop star sings “No longer drowning and deceived/ All because you came for me”?

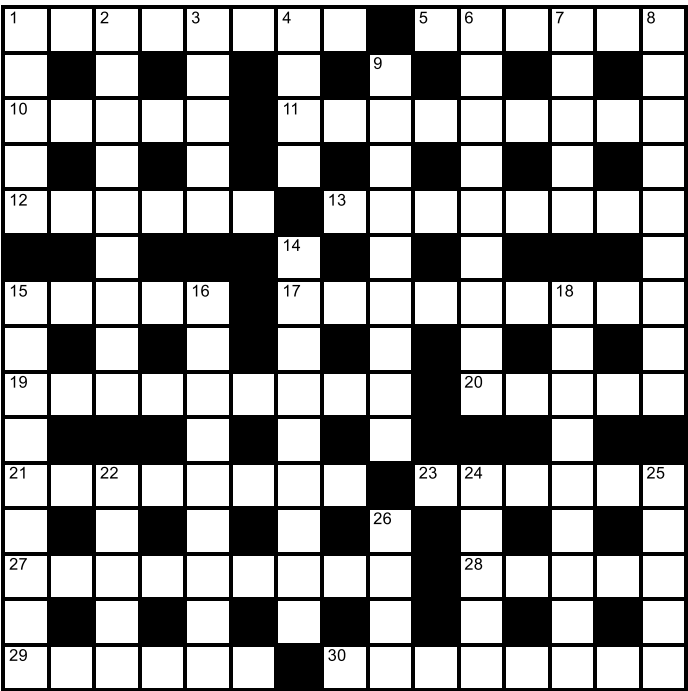
An acclaimed Bollywood director made a trilogy of movies based on the works of Shakespeare. They revolve around the Mumbai underworld, Uttar Pradesh politics and the Kashmir conflict, respectively. Which three tragedies are these films adapted from?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Moons of Jovianus
- 2. Break the ice
- 3. Julius Caesar
- 4. It’s all Greek to me
- 5. Wild-geese chase
- 6. In a pickle
- 7. Cold-blooded
- 8. King Lear
- 9. Taylor Swift
- 10. Macbeth, Othello & Hamlet

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 53 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 1 Murder drunk medico going behind hospital around one (8)
 - 5 Robert traps a sailor in tree (6)
 - 10 Horse carriage available in Daltonganj (5)
 - 11 Part, carrying writer, with right pencil refurbishment device (9)
 - 12 Student rolls eye on receiving Chinese fruit (6)
 - 13 See cross arranged for film-maker (8)
 - 15 Citadels for tired soldiers, for starters (5)
 - 17 Arranged big deal to get indebted (9)
 - 19 Heaters in rooms and coolers in cars? (9)
 - 20 After Japanese drink, Romeo gets falcon (5)
 - 21 Setter wrongly printed “Brave” (8)
 - 23 Charlie also ran more near (6)
 - 27 Forceful blows from husband destroys easy mark (9)
 - 28 Twelve dozen without tax deduction (5)
 - 29 Peril from starting to drive with ire (6)
 - 30 Peppers and horribly irks papa (8)

- Down**
- 1 Extremely warm in front of the Spanish accommodation for guests (5)
 - 2 Chap one treated successfully groomed hands (9)
 - 3 Box containing rodent in church (5)
 - 4 Some Hindus know the time when there is a little light before commencement of night (4)
 - 6 Snake sitting on a piece of cloth next to

- American vegetable (9)
- 7 Loveless game starting to excite party (5)
- 8 Prohibit sore saloon worker (9)
- 9 Extraordinary smoker having a lighter perhaps (9)
- 14 Settled: “Is editor” (9)
- 15 Groped around vessel provided (9)
- 16 Boy leaves stud farm employee? It’s an impasse... (9)
- 18 Assess the situation and steal cattle (4,5)
- 22 In absence of a notary, change and check suitability of suit, for example (3-2)
- 24 Extraordinarily large beer (5)
- 25 Gets up, sir, in confusion about directions (5)
- 26 Runt leaves Austrian in continent (4)

SOLUTION NO. 52

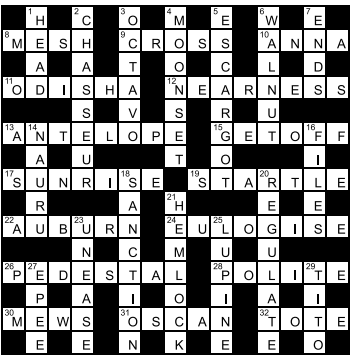




ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

Tharsni M.
tharsnitheivalakshmi@gmail.com

In the 21st century, a woman can map the human genome, lead a boardroom, or draft national policy. Yet, upon returning home, her entire intellectual and professional worth is often reduced to a single, archaic litmus test: Can she cook? Can she draw a *kolam*? Can she string flowers? Society loves to congratulate itself on “allowing” women into the workforce, but the yardstick used to measure them remains rusted and stuck in the past. We have created a world where women are expected to conquer the public sphere while remaining perfectly submissive to the private one. We do not just want women to succeed; we demand they succeed twice.

I was recently reminded of this absurdity. When I told a person I did not know how to string flowers, the response was not a shrug – it was a sarcastic, disappointed barb: “Don’t be proud of that.” In that one sentence, my degrees, my research, and my professional labour evaporated. I was not a person with a career; I was a “failure” of a woman because I lacked a specific, decorative domestic skill. The irony? This judgment often comes from other women, the primary enforcers of a patriarchal code that serves no one.

Let’s be honest: the “double shift” isn’t an accident; it’s a design flaw. Society applauds the “modern woman” but quietly ensures the domestic

Unacceptable yardsticks

Why is a woman still being judged by how she cooks and how she strings flowers?

workload remains her shadow. We have rebranded “burden” as “multitasking” and “exhaustion” as “strength”. The problem is not the traditions themselves – there is beauty in a *kolam* and artistry in traditional cooking. The problem is when these skills transition from choices to compulsory markers of worth. When a woman’s competence in the lab or the office is invalidated by a burnt meal or a bare doorstep, one is not practising culture, but practising control.

True empowerment is not the freedom to say “yes” to a career; it is the radical, unapologetic freedom to say “no” to the chores. We must normalise a woman’s right to decide what she does not want to learn or do. We celebrate women who

add new roles to their lives – CEO, doctor, pilot – but we recoil from women who subtract traditional ones. If a woman chooses to learn a craft, let it be for her joy, not her justification. If she chooses to ignore it, that refusal should be treated with the same respect as her professional ambitions.

Society cannot claim a woman is “free” if she is only applauded for choices that meet social approval. The freedom to define one’s identity must include the freedom to reject expectations that do not align with one’s aspirations. Just as it is normal for a man to lack “domestic competence” without his masculinity being questioned, it must become normal for a woman to say, “This role is not for me.”

One needs to stop asking if women are failing to meet society’s expectations. Instead, ask why society’s expectations are so spectacularly failing women. A woman is not a checklist of household chores wrapped in a professional blazer. She is a human being, and her value is inherent; not something she has to prove at the stove or on the porch at dawn. The *kolam* may be beautiful, but the cage built around it is not. It’s time to break the frame.

True empowerment isn’t about how well a woman can string flowers; it’s about her right to say she is not interested to learn it. If her value is only as deep as a petal, then your version of “progress” is already wilting. If you are looking for someone to stay within the lines, you have picked the wrong generation; we aren’t here to decorate your doorstep, we are here to break down the door.

The echo of unwritten words

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Tucked away in my bookshelf is a book of quotes by famous people. Reading this brings to mind words from a person more familiar and dear to me and in fact, to all of us. I am referring to mothers.

Some words always linger in our subconscious mind and tend to come to the forefront and help us just when we need them. Wherever we are, mother’s words – her unwritten rules, pithy sayings, dollops of wisdom which we often tend to ignore, and laugh at – act like an anchor to steady us during troublesome moments, echoing constantly within us, reiterating the fact that mothers “do know”.

I recall some of her utterances: take a walk or water the plants to calm down; learn to adapt as there are all kinds of people in the world; everyone makes mistakes but try to learn from it; gulp down some water when you are struggling with anger; a short nap will work wonders; don’t forget to appreciate; listen patiently to what a child says; look at what you have and not at what you don’t have.

Sometimes, there is humour tinged with wisdom in her words which gives us pointers to how to tackle any situation.

When dealing with rebellious teens, she would say give them a long rope, adding that stubbornness cannot be tackled with stubbornness. Ride along with them and gently manoeuvre them onto your track. Don’t compare, put pressure or be judgmental. Her mantra was “remember to emphasise the positives”.

On dealing with the repercussions of using harsh words, she would use the local language to add some punch, saying you can throw words down but you cannot gather them back.

On a motivating note, she would firmly say that there are a lot of people in the world to put you down. “Take their negativity through one ear and let it go through the other ear. Believe in yourself.”

Often, I can hear her soft, calming voice telling an anxious and stressed mind, “Go to sleep, for tomorrow is a new day.” Even amid turmoil, she would never fail to ask if you had eaten for she believed that putting some food in the stomach would help see things in a better light. I have no notebook or codebook with mother’s words or sayings which I can use as a ready reckoner to deal with any situation but mother’s words tend to be deeply embedded in the mind.

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A choice I had to make in a recent morning was should I do my stretches, calf raises, and ankle rotation in the sun for 10 minutes or should I sit inside and read *Super Agers* sipping lemon water with turmeric and ginger. In opting for the latter, I would avoid sun spots, get glowing skin, and know clever stuff about gut microbiome. I could then be the light and joy of the building association meeting at which the actual topic would be when to repair the lift, but I would be glowing and talking about the gut.

You know what I chose...

Choices used to be simple in the good old days: should you take chemistry, physics, and biology or physics, chemistry, and maths; should you cut your hair short or wear it long; or should you buy a Kinetic Honda or a Scooty.

Now you need to decide whether to take medical insurance from this company or that; whether you should travel in premium economy or economy; whether you

Harried by choices

A surfeit of them touch a raw nerve almost daily, taking time and energy

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should go to Cambodia or Vietnam for your holiday (what is the difference); should you throw out all the non-stick cookware and buy cast-iron stuff... this is linked to your insurance cover, whether it includes wrist surgery or not. There are so many suggestions. Eight different ways to make your plants grow, 15 “must watch” movies, and 450 beauty hacks for skin and hair. But then let us get back to choices.

In defence

One problem with making your own choices is that you may have to defend them. And if you have based that choice on sitting in your favourite chair a little longer, you may not have a defence that makes you look good.

Take post-retirement activity. Every man around

you talks of being productive and active when they land a paying job. On the other hand, they talk of giving back to society, contentment and connecting, when they do not have a paying job. Women throw you into a different cauldron, in which jobs are only one part of the mix. They find activities which should be banned such as decoupage, quilling, making sesame seed crisps, repurposing saris into stuff that you may never use, or making their own shampoo. After a glass or two of wine, both genders confess that what they really love doing is watching English crime series on OTT services and cooking eggs in 50 different ways.

A lot of us have chosen to follow online yoga every day. The instructors’

selling point is that they tell you all the time that you can do less, you can do an easier version, and you can just sit and breath through your nose instead of your mouth. They often use the term “nice and easy”, which is why I chose one of them and by jove, I am going to stick with him.

There are other things I have chosen to do: to stack my newspapers properly, to fold my clothes as soon as they are dry to avoid ironing, to sit with my maid with a cup of tea and hear her talk about her family, to laugh very loudly when I see or read something funny, to cry when I read about a starving child, to curse when I see a leader of a nation commit genocide. I have chosen to keep in touch with friends through inane messages, silly jokes, and pointless phone conversations, and I have chosen to reply to messages sent by people who are old and who are possibly feeling lonely.

There may be a million important things that I have not chosen: learning AI for example, but I am pretty happy with the things I have chosen, an important one being buying a pair of shoes with arch support.



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of health has increased. People now understand the dangers of tobacco.

There is also a warning on every packet of cigarettes. It clearly says that smoking is injurious to health. Still, many people ignore it.

Even with rules in place, the habit continues. People often go outside buildings to smoke. After smoking, they crush the cigarette under their foot. But many times, the end is



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Erasing Mughals from Indian history is neither possible nor desirable. (‘Living with the Mughals’; April 19) A mature society acknowledges all pasts – complex, contested and interconnected. Any attempt to erase a part of history leads to distortion and intellectual impoverishment.

N.S. Reddy

The article offers a nuanced and compelling reflection of the enduring legacy of the Mughal Empire. At a time when there are increasing attempts to dilute such historical contributions from academic discourse, this piece stands as an important reminder of the dangers of curated history.

Sam Alexander P.J.

The contribution of the Mughals is not a matter of ideology but of documented fact. Removing them from textbooks doesn’t rewrite history – it simply leaves students ill-equipped to understand the country they inhabit.

A. Myilsami

Beacon of hope

The piece beautifully foregrounds translation as a silent yet powerful force that sustains literature across languages and generations. (‘Notes from the black box’; April 19) In an age where the habit of reading is diminishing, such reflections remind us that accessibility through translation can rekindle literary engagement among diverse audiences.

A. Abarna

Insightful read

As a passionate student of history, I find it deeply intriguing to engage with a

rigorous scholarly work that thoughtfully weaves together memoir with meticulous analysis. (‘In Gulbadan’s world’; April 19) The well-crafted introduction further enhances its intellectual appeal.

Aftab Abdulkader

Remembering the past

While it is an undisputed fact that some monuments are more popular than others where footfalls are concerned, that in no way reduces their significance or their appeal. (‘Walk a hidden royal trail’; April 19) The analysis of these monuments by experts reveals their intrinsic features and why they too should find a place of pride in India’s illustrious list of monuments.

C.V. Aravind

Uncertain future

When war is framed like a video game, public sensitivity to human suffering erodes. (‘Lost in rhetoric’; April 19) Donald Trump’s narcissistic communication style turns complex diplomacy into spectacle, raising serious concerns about whether nuclear capabilities are in safe hands.

Harsh Pawaria

Still relevant

While the article thoughtfully traces Narada’s evolution from mischief-maker to cultural icon, it could have explored more how such mythological figures continue to shape everyday ethics and storytelling. (‘Narada: the original provocateur’; April 19) Perhaps future pieces might include voices from regional traditions to make these connections even more relevant and accessible for contemporary audiences.

Abbharna Barathi



MORE ON THE WEB

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Book talk

Books seem to keep the whole world within them but exist in this world with such modesty

Viji Narayan

Watching TV for the ads

Back then, advertisements were imaginative and entertaining

Rishi Kanna

Memories of a guava tree

The sentient observer taught invaluable lessons in developing patience

Shalini M.

The song of the garden

The flowers and leaves make it a sublime raga

H. Kalpana Rao

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